

confused and misinformed about what it means to be rich. Most Americans have no idea about the true inner workings of a wealthy household. The advertising industry and Hollywood have done a wonderful job conditioning us to believe that wealth and hyperconsumption go hand in hand. Yet, as I have said many times, the large majority of the rich live well below their means. Unfortunately, most Americans think that they are emulating the rich by immediately consuming any upward swing in their cash flow.

But the millionaire-next-door types do it differently. As one millionaire woman trained as an engineer told me, “After college my husband (also an engineer) and I both got good jobs. We lived on one income and saved the other. Anytime we got raises we just saved more. We have lived in the same modest 1,900-square-foot home for twenty years.... Sometimes my kids ask if we are poor because I make them order from the \$1 value menu.”

America is still the land of opportunity. Over the past thirty years I have consistently found that 80 to 85 percent of millionaires are self-made. There is great pride, joy and satisfaction to be derived from building one’s own fortune. Countless millionaires have told me that the journey to wealth is much more satisfying than the destination. When they look back over their history of building wealth, they recall constantly setting economic goals and the great happiness gained from achieving them. Yes, in the context of economic achievement, it is the trip, the journey to financial independence about which the millionaires next door most often boast.

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